

You are paying more to eat worse.

One dish at each of 87 restaurants, across 43 cuisines, scored on seven health measures plus how good it tastes and what it costs. The most consistent finding was the one nobody wanted.

87	43	14	+0.05
DISHES SCORED	CUISINES	GOOD AND UNDER \$16	PRICE VS HEALTH



And 1.1g less fibre. The health score moves +0.04 – which, on a ten-point scale, is nothing at all.

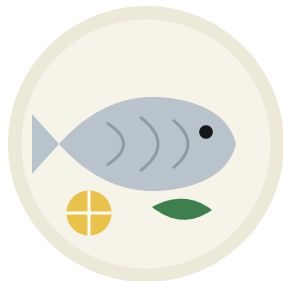
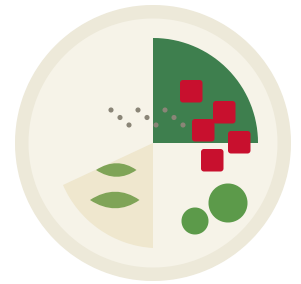
+105

MILLIGRAMS OF SALT
FOR EVERY EXTRA \$5
YOU SPEND

Spending more makes the meal worse

Across sixty dishes, every additional \$5 on the bill brings 105 more milligrams of sodium and 1.1g less fibre – and moves the health score by +0.04, which is nothing. Price and health correlate at +0.05. Money is not neutral here. It is mildly harmful.

Stop treating the expensive option as the careful one.



Every dish over \$17 is beaten by a cheaper one

Only four dishes in the whole set are efficient – meaning nothing cheaper is also as healthy. All 30 priced above \$17.00 are matched or beaten by something that costs less. Chengdu 7 charges \$36.95 for a health score Chopt reaches at \$10.79.

\$17.00

THE PRICE ABOVE WHICH
NOTHING IS EFFICIENT

Treat \$17.00 as a ceiling, not a floor.

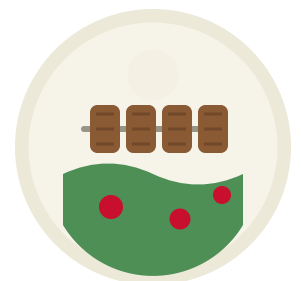
+572

EXTRA MILLIGRAMS OF
SALT IN THE FOOD THAT
TASTES BEST

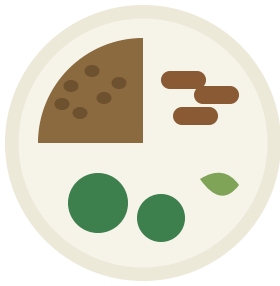
Flavour is bought with salt, not fat

The dishes that taste best carry +572mg more sodium than the blandest ones – but only +2.0g more saturated fat, which is statistical noise. A quarter of what money appears to buy in flavour is simply salt. Everyone is watching the wrong nutrient.

Watch the sauce, the base and the cure. Stop watching the olive oil.



Which dish you order beats where you order it



The gap between the best and worst thing on a single menu (1.44 points) is wider than the gap across the middle half of every restaurant in the set (1.25). One place spans 2.77 points on its own menu – from a dish that ranks near the top to one near the bottom.

1.44

POINTS BETWEEN THE
BEST AND WORST ORDER
AT ONE RESTAURANT

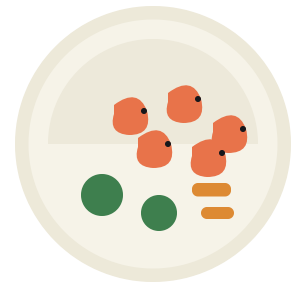
Picking the restaurant is the smaller half of the
decision.

The cheapest protein here is also the cleanest

\$0.19

PER GRAM OF PROTEIN –
THE CHEAPEST AND THE
CLEANEST AT ONCE

DICED's lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken is \$10.95 for 57g of protein, the best value in the set – and it carries 2.5mg of sodium per gram of that protein, also the best in the set. Cheap and clean are usually a trade. Here they are the same bowl.



| If you order one thing off this list, order that.

The cheap week beats the expensive one



Five dinners chosen by picking the top-ranked dishes cost \$93.10 and leave their weakest nutritional gap at 7.3 out of 10. Five chosen as the cheapest that still clear that bar cost \$61.93 – and close the gap to 7.9. Cheaper and better, not cheaper and worse.

\$31.17

SAVED ON A WEEK OF
DINNERS, WITH BETTER
COVERAGE

Rotate, do not climb the ranking.

WHAT TO ORDER

Nine plates that survive the arithmetic

Cheap, high in protein, low in salt, and – where we could manage it – worth eating. Prices are what the delivery app charges, which runs about 15% above the counter.



Lentil-base bowl with grilled chicken

DICED

\$10.95

57g protein · 144mg salt

Lentils carry 20g of protein at 4mg of sodium, so the bowl lands at 144mg – the cleanest protein-to-salt ratio anywhere in the set.



Craft Your Own salad, grilled chicken

Chopt

\$10.79

33g protein · 735mg salt

The cheapest dish in the whole set, and it still clears the health bar. Take the vinaigrette light; it is most of the sugar.



Grilled chicken bowl

Guasaca

\$11.21

42g protein · 1,050mg salt

Order it as a bowl, never as an arepa – the arepa is refined corn flour and carries most of the calories.



¼ Chicken w/ White Combo

Alpaca Peruvian Charcoal Chicken

\$11.29

53g protein · 1,310mg salt

Two sides are included and the salad sits in the same tier as the fries. Taking them is the entire decision.



Large chicken bowl on salad base

Pokeworks

\$16.00

43g protein · 535mg salt

Their chicken is 80mg of sodium a scoop against ahi tuna at 350. Almost nobody orders chicken at a poke restaurant.



Double tuna salad bowl

Poke Bros.

\$17.00

51g protein · 201mg salt

Plain tuna is 40mg of sodium; their own marinated tuna is 820. The house sauce is added automatically unless you refuse it.



Sizzling fish with vermicelli and herbs

Taste Vietnamese

\$17.95

40g protein · 1,300mg salt

The best-tasting dish in the set that still scores well – grilled turmeric fish with a herb plate, sauce on the side.



Chicken kebab plate with fattoush and tzatziki

Baba Ghannouj

\$15.99

44g protein · 1,200mg salt

Char, sumac and lemon do the work instead of fat. Swap the rice for extra salad and skip the fried pita chips.



D6. Steamed Shrimp with Mixed Vegetables Diet

Golden Dragon

\$12.39

37g protein · 940mg salt

Every Chinese takeout prints a diet menu and nobody orders from it. Steamed, sauce on the side, no oil – for \$12.39.

And six that do not

Not because they are indulgent – because they cost as much as the good ones and give nothing back.

A margherita pizza Pizzeria Toro	The dough alone is about 1,475mg of sodium at the standard salt ratio.
Braised oxtail Gifted Hand Cuisine	16g of saturated fat – most of a day, in one plate.
Beef kobidah Afghan Kebab	Ground meat, white rice and bread; 11g saturated fat before the sauce.
Two beef empanadas Makus Empanadas	Baked rather than fried, and still 905 calories for 31g of protein.
Carne asada plate MI CANCUN	13g saturated fat, 1,600mg sodium, and \$24.99.
A loaded poke bowl Bul Box	Sauces and pickles push it to 1,951mg – more than a bowl of ramen.

\$31.17 is the price of following the ranking

FIVE DINNERS, PICKED FROM THE TOP

\$93.10

WEAKEST NUTRITIONAL GAP 7.3 / 10

M Sushi	\$31.20
Taste Vietnamese	\$17.95
Poke Bros.	\$17.00
Pokeworks	\$16.00
DICED	\$10.95

FIVE DINNERS, PICKED FOR VALUE

\$61.93

WEAKEST NUTRITIONAL GAP 7.9 / 10 – BETTER

Abol Ethiopian	\$16.99
Southern Spice	\$11.99
Guasaca	\$11.21
DICED	\$10.95
Chopt	\$10.79

HOW THIS WAS PUT TOGETHER

What was measured

Each entry is one specific dish, ordered one specific way. Seven health measures – sodium, saturated fat and calories, protein, fermented food and plant variety, refined carbohydrate, omega-3, and sugar – plus flavour and cost. Where the instruction says to refuse something, the figures assume you refused it.

Where the numbers come from

Nine dishes are built from figures the restaurant publishes. The rest are estimated from how the dish is constructed, and the full document marks which is which.

What it cannot tell you

No restaurant that cooks to order over fire publishes nutrition data, so every grilled, stewed and steamed dish here is an estimate. When we rebuilt dishes against a restaurant's own figures, eleven of thirteen turned out worse than estimated – so read an estimate as roughly half a point generous.

Not medical advice

This compares restaurant meals with each other. It is not a diagnosis, and the thresholds behind the scores are judgement calls, argued out in the full document.

The illustrations are drawings of dish types, not photographs of any particular restaurant's food. Prices and menus change constantly; every figure here has a shelf life measured in months.